REFORM EXPRESS



Union railways minister **Ashwini Vaishnaw** has promised 52 reforms for the 52 weeks of 2026. Framed as part of PM Narendra Modi's broader reform push, the plan spans AI-assisted maintenance, tighter safety compliance, staff retraining and improved catering. Critics will note that the railways have survived decades with far fewer course corrections, but the pressure now is speed: as one reform gets under way, another piles on. Cleaner toilets, punctual trains, faster overnight services... By this time next year, Rail Bhawan mandarins will be scrambling to keep pace.

DOUBLE OR DABBA



Prime Minister Narendra Modi's pitch for a "double engine" government in Tamil Nadu, made during his visit to the state, drew a sharp rebuttal from CM **M.K. Stalin**. Dismissing the BJP's slogan, Stalin quipped that the much-touted double engine was in fact a "dabba engine", adding that states such as TN, Kerala and West Bengal had achieved growth precisely because there was no double engine. The dry humour sliced through familiar campaign rhetoric and set the tone for the sniper fire that followed.

Veggie Tyranny



On the inaugural Kolkata-Kamakhya run of the Vande Bharat, Bengal found an unexpected bone of contention: vegetarian cutlets. The ruling Trinamool Congress cried foul, arguing that in poll-bound Bengal, many things are negotiable, but not "mandatory vegetarianism". In a rare crossover moment, Bengal BJP chief **Samik Bhattacharya** agreed, asking why a civilisation built on fish should be fed soy. Calm returned after Union minister Sukanta Majumdar's assurances that non-vegetarian food would soon be served.

Kaushik Deka with Avishek G. Dastidar, Kavitha Muralidharan, Rohit Parihar and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

ECO WATCH

DEEPFAKE WILDLIFE VIDEOS
AI OF THE TIGER

By **Rahul Noronha**

In October 2025, a video showing a man petting a tiger and offering him a swig of liquor went viral. Claims were made that the video was from Seoni, the district in MP that houses the renowned Pench National Park. Later, it came about that the video was AI-generated.



Deepfake wildlife videos are the latest challenge wildlife managers across the country, and indeed the world, are facing. So, what is the issue with such wildlife videos? "Well, there are areas where man-animal conflict is more pronounced than other areas. In such places, proliferation of videos that show animals, especially tigers or leopards, as aggressive can add to tensions between communities, wildlife and wildlife managers," says L. Krishnamurthy, additional principal chief conservator of forests wildlife, MP.

AI-generated wildlife videos are of both types, showing animals as aggressive as well as kind and, well, friendly. "That is a problem too," says Krishnamurthy, "because it is creating a false idea of animal behavior in the minds of the uninformed."

There was a move to amend the IT Act to get AI-generated videos to carry a warning and hologram to suggest they are not real. Nothing has come of it, and no legal action has been taken against those who make these videos. With no legal framework in place, awareness campaigns remain the only option. Man and animal must co-exist, but now it seems wildlife will have to deal with AI deepfakes too.